

□ Reflection 3 □

Yadā Yadā — The Eternal Recurrence of Dharma : यदा यदा

On the cycle in which the same truth has been spoken, again and again, in many voices

A note to the reader. This reflection observes a pattern — that the same essential teaching has surfaced, across centuries and continents, in voices that did not know one another and that spoke through very different traditions, languages, and idioms. It is not a claim that these voices are interchangeable, nor that the traditions they spoke from can be collapsed into a single religion, nor that their disagreements on specifics do not matter. They are not interchangeable. The traditions cannot be collapsed. The disagreements do matter. The pattern observed here is something quieter and more interesting: that, beneath the diversity of forms, a single quiet teaching seems unable to stop being offered, and human beings seem unable to stop forgetting it. The reflection is offered in that spirit — as observation, not as theology, and not as a comment on any contemporary situation.

The verse, read carefully

The Bhagavad Gītā contains a single, often-quoted promise about the future of truth itself. It is usually read as a religious doctrine — a particular god's announcement that he will incarnate again and again in a particular land. It can also be read, more carefully, as a description of how truth actually behaves over time:

यदा यदा हि धर्मस्य ग्लानिर्भवति भारत ।
अभ्युत्थानमधर्मस्य तदात्मानं सृजाम्यहम् ॥ ४.७ ॥

*yadā yadā hi dharmasya glānir bhavati bhārata |
abhyutthānam adharmasya tadātmānaṁ sṛjāmy aham | |*

**"Whenever the upholding-truth weakens, O Bhārata,
and what is contrary to it rises —
then I send forth Myself."**

The Sanskrit is precise. **Yadā yadā** — "whenever, whenever" — the doubled adverb implies *every time, recurrently, in every era*. **Dharmasya glāniḥ** — "weakening of dharma" — not the weakening of any particular community, but the weakening of *the upholding-truth itself*, the cosmic-ethical principle that holds human life in alignment with reality. **Tadā ātmānaṁ sṛjāmy aham** — "then I send forth Myself" — in the present tense, in the active voice, as an open-ended structural promise, not a closed historical event.

Most translations restrict this verse to a particular avatāra tradition: the doctrine that *Viṣṇu* takes one of *ten* bodily forms (Matsya, Kūrma, Varāha, Narasiṁha, Vāmana, Paraśurāma, Rāma, Kṛṣṇa, Buddha, Kalki) to restore dharma. This is a beautiful tradition. It is also a partial reading. The Sanskrit of 4.7 itself names no list, no number, no geography, and no particular form. It says only: *when the upholding-truth weakens, I send forth Myself. Whenever. Wherever. By whatever means.*

Read this way, the verse becomes not a sectarian doctrine but an empirical claim — one that can be checked against history. Has the same truth, in fact, kept surfacing, in many voices, across many traditions and centuries? If yes, the Gītā's promise is being fulfilled in a deeper sense than the avatāra-list captures. If no, the Gītā would seem to be making an empty boast.

The remainder of this reflection is a check against history.

The pattern

What follows are voices, in approximate chronological order, that the wisdom literature of the world has produced. Each spoke from a different culture, in a different language, often without knowledge of the others. Each one's tradition has its own internal disagreements; the differences among them are real. And yet, on a

small core of teachings, the voices coincide in a way that — if one had not been told it was the wisdom literature of separate civilizations — would seem to be the work of a single, very patient hand.

The teachings on which they coincide are these. **One:** there is something real and gentle beneath the surface of the world, and human beings are not separate from it. **Two:** the path to it is not through more grasping, but through less. **Three:** the response to hatred is not more hatred, but its opposite. **Four:** the deepest action is the action that does not claim itself. **Five:** see the same inner reality in every other being, and act accordingly.

These five teachings, in essentially these words, have been spoken by every voice in the table below. They have, also, been ignored by essentially every age in which they were spoken. The voices are humble about this; they do not pretend to have solved the human problem. They only offer the same medicine, in their own dialect, to those who will receive it.

The voices

Īśā Upaniṣad, verse 1

India · approximate composition ca. 800–500 BCE · Sanskrit

ईशा वास्यमिदं सर्वं यत्किञ्च जगत्यां जगत् ।
तेन त्यक्तेन भुञ्जीथा मा गृधः कस्यस्विद्धनम् ॥

īśā vāsyam idaṁ sarvaṁ yat kiñca jagatyāṁ jagat |
tena tyaktena bhuñjīthā mā grdhaḥ kasya svid dhanam | |

"All this — whatever moves in this moving world — is enveloped by the Lord.
By renouncing, enjoy. Do not covet anyone's wealth."

The world is not yours to clutch; it is the Divine's, and lent to you. The way to truly enjoy it is to release the clutching. Two thousand five hundred years before Stoicism and Buddhism, the same recognition.

The Buddha — Dhammapada, verse 5

India · ca. 500 BCE · Pāli (closely related to Sanskrit)

na hi verena verāni sammantīdha kudācanaṁ |
averena ca sammanti — esa dhammo sanantano | |

"Hatred is never appeased by hatred in this world.
By non-hatred alone is it appeased.
This is the eternal law (sanātana dhamma)."

The phrase sanātana dhamma means "the eternal upholding-truth" — the same compound the Gītā uses to describe its own teaching. The Buddha and the Gītā agree on the law.

Bhagavad Gītā 2.47

India · ca. 500–200 BCE · Sanskrit

कर्मण्येवाधिकारस्ते मा फलेषु कदाचन ।
मा कर्मफलहेतुर्भूर्मा ते सङ्गोऽस्त्वकर्मणि ॥

karmaṇy evādhikāras te mā phaleṣu kadācana |
mā karma-phala-hetur bhūr mā te saṅgo 'stv akarmaṇi | |

"You have the right to action alone — never to its fruits.
Be not the cause of the fruit; nor let your attachment be to inaction."

Act fully. Release the outcome. Do not refuse to act because you cannot control the result. This is, in a single verse, the deepest practical teaching the Gītā gives — and the one closest to the heart of nonviolent action two and a half millennia later.

Lao Tzu — Tao Te Ching, chapter 8

China · ca. 6th century BCE (traditional dating; some scholars place later) · Classical Chinese

上善若水。水善利萬物而不爭
(shàng shàn ruò shuǐ. shuǐ shàn lì wàn wù ér bù zhēng)

"The highest goodness is like water.
Water benefits all things and does not contend."

Wu-wei — effortless, non-contending action. Flow rather than fight. The Tao Te Ching is, in many places, almost a Chinese commentary on the Gītā that could not have known the Gītā existed.

Jesus of Nazareth — Sermon on the Mount, Matthew 5:39, 44

Roman Palestine · ca. 30 CE · originally spoken in Aramaic, recorded in Koine Greek

ἐγὼ δὲ λέγω ὑμῖν μὴ ἀντιστῆναι τῷ πονηρῷ... ἀγαπᾶτε τοὺς ἐχθροὺς ὑμῶν, καὶ προσεύχεσθε ὑπὲρ τῶν
διωκόντων ὑμᾶς.

(egō de legō hymin: mē antistēnai tō ponērō ... agapate tous echthrous hymōn)

Mohandas Gandhi — *Anāsakti Yoga* (his Gujarati commentary on the Gītā)

India · 1929 · Gujarati (later translated to English)

"My life is my message. Renounce and enjoy."

The three-word summary of an entire life, drawn directly from the Īśā Upaniṣad: *tena tyaktena bhuñjīthaḥ*. By renouncing, enjoy.

Gandhi had read Tolstoy's *Letter to a Hindu* in 1909, while practicing law in South Africa. He requested permission to translate it. He named his second ashram in South Africa "Tolstoy Farm." He then spent four decades demonstrating, in the largest empirical experiment in nonviolent political action in modern history, that the teaching could in fact be lived in public. He died in 1948, shot by a fellow Hindu who believed that Gandhi had been too kind to Muslims.

Martin Luther King Jr. — *Strength to Love* and *Letter from Birmingham Jail*

United States · 1963 · English

"Returning hate for hate multiplies hate, adding deeper darkness to a night already devoid of stars. Darkness cannot drive out darkness; only light can do that. Hate cannot drive out hate; only love can do that."

The same teaching — the Buddha's *averena ca sammanti*, the Gītā's *akrodha*, the Sermon on the Mount's *do not resist evil* — now in the English of mid-20th-century Atlanta.

King had read Gandhi (extensively, beginning at Crozer Theological Seminary in 1949) and had visited India in 1959. He drew his political method explicitly from Gandhi, who had drawn it explicitly from the Gītā and Tolstoy, who had drawn it explicitly from Jesus and the Buddha. King was assassinated in 1968, five years after writing these words.

The pattern observed

Lay these voices side by side, and three observations become hard to deny.

First: the teaching is the same. The vocabulary changes — *dharma*, *dhamma*, *tao*, *halakhah*, *logos*, "the law of love" — but the underlying counsel does not. Act without claiming. Release the clutching. Do not return hatred for hatred. See the same reality in the one you are tempted to hate. This is one teaching, in many languages.

Second: the voices did not, in most cases, copy from one another. The Buddha did not read the Gītā. Lao Tzu did not read either. Jesus did not read the Tao Te Ching. Rūmī did not read the Sermon on the Mount in its original. The teaching surfaced in independent cultures, often in independent centuries, often in voices that had no plausible mechanism of borrowing. Where later voices did read earlier ones — Tolstoy reading the Gītā, Gandhi reading Tolstoy, King reading Gandhi — the chain is documented and visible. But the deeper coincidence runs through voices that had no such chain. They were, somehow, drawing from the same well.

Third: the teaching was, in each age, almost completely ignored — and yet it kept being offered. The Buddha taught for forty-five years; the world has not become non-hating. The Sermon on the Mount has been the central text of a global civilization for two thousand years; that civilization has, in fact, returned hatred for hatred on a vast scale. Gandhi's method liberated a subcontinent and was then almost immediately abandoned by the inheritors of that liberation. King's method bent the moral arc of one country slightly, briefly, and the bending has been resisted ever since. And yet the teaching keeps being given. The voices keep coming. *Yadā yadā hi dharmasya*.

This is what the Gītā's verse means in its widest sense. Whenever the upholding-truth weakens — somewhere, somehow — the same truth speaks again. Not always in Sanskrit. Not always in robes. Not always in a body that wins its argument. Often in a body that is, by the world's standards, killed for its trouble. But the truth keeps surfacing. **The list above is not closed.** Whoever speaks the next verse of it is, perhaps, already speaking, in some language that none of the previous voices used, in some place where one of the previous voices is being most thoroughly forgotten.

The implication, lightly held

An observation, not a doctrine: every age that has forgotten this teaching has paid the same price. The price is not subtle. It is the cost in blood, in displacement, in burnt cities, in inherited grief, that is paid whenever a community decides — for whatever reason it gives itself — that the law of the matter is "we against them" rather

than "the upholding-truth, against forgetfulness." The Mahābhārata is, among other things, a long meditation on this price. It does not end with one side winning and the other losing. It ends with both sides equally devastated, the victors burying their own children in the morning after the war.

This is also why the Gītā, in the middle of that very war, stops the action and offers, for 700 verses, a teaching about something other than winning. The teaching is not given *after* the war, as a post-mortem; it is given *during* the war, when the wheels of vengeance are already turning, because the moment when one most needs the teaching is the moment when one is least able to hear it. The text is offered in that moment, knowing full well that most of its readers will receive it too late — and that the offering itself is still worth making, because some readers, somewhere, in some generation, will hear in time.

The unspoken present

These reflections were begun in a particular year, in a world that the writer can describe only in the most general terms. Wars are being fought, somewhere. Identities are being defended, somewhere, against other identities. Old grievances are being revived, in places where the previous round of grievance had not yet healed. Books and broadcasts and platforms are being used, in old languages and new, to make the case that *we* are righteous and *they* are not. The wheels of vengeance are, as in every age, turning.

Every reader of this reflection lives somewhere on that map. Every reader has a side that they feel is the side of justice; an enemy they feel is the enemy of justice; a grief or a fear they feel has not been taken seriously by the world. The reflection does not ask the reader to abandon their grief, deny their fear, or pretend they have no enemy. The Gītā never asked Arjuna to do any of those things either. Arjuna's grief was real. His enemies were real. His fear was real. The teaching was given *to him in that condition*, not to a man who had already transcended it.

What the teaching asks is something simpler, and more demanding: *that, even from inside the grief, even with the enemy in plain sight, even when fear is doing its work — the seeker examine, honestly, whether they have allowed their identity-labels to do their thinking for them. Whether the line they are drawing between us and them is, in fact, a line that runs along the upholding-truth, or one that runs along their own forgetting of it.*

This is a question every reader must ask of themselves. It is not a question this reflection can ask for them. Every "they" is somebody else's "we." Every certainty about the other side's blindness is itself a candidate for blindness. The Gītā, having said "these warriors are already slain by Me; be the instrument, but do not claim the slaying" in 11.34, was not licensing Arjuna's hatred. It was releasing him from the need to hate while doing the work that he, alone among the living, could do. The teaching applies, in proportion, to every seeker who has ever stood on a field, of any kind, with a hard decision in front of them.

The closing recognition

If these three reflections have done their work, what they have offered is small, technical, and quiet. The word *dharma* has been returned, by a few inches, to what it actually means. The verses of the Gītā have been allowed to speak for themselves about how the Divine receives different paths. The pattern of voices through which the same teaching keeps being offered, century after century, has been laid out in plain order. These are not large claims. They are corrections to a few translations, and an observation about a pattern that anyone who looks can verify for themselves.

And yet, if the corrections are accurate, and if the observation is true, then something follows that is not small. It is this:

The wisdom literature of the world — including the literature of the tradition each reader was happens to have been born into — is, on the question of what to do with one's life, more in agreement than the inheritors of that literature usually let on. The disagreements are on the details. The agreement, on the heart of the matter, is nearly complete. And the heart of the matter is something every reader has already heard, many times, in some language: be honest. Be kind. Do your own work. Do not return hatred for hatred. Release what cannot be controlled. See the other person — even the one most clearly opposed to you — as one in whom the same reality is at stake. Act from that recognition, even when the world will not yet act with you.

This is not, by any reasonable definition, a doctrine. It is what is left when the doctrines have been heard with care, and what they shared has been allowed to come forward. It is the same thing every generation has been told and has, mostly, declined to hear. It is what the Gītā offers in Sanskrit, what the Buddha offered in Pāli, what Lao Tzu offered in Chinese, what Jesus offered in Aramaic, what Rūmī offered in Persian, what Tolstoy offered in

Russian, what Gandhi offered in Gujarati, what King offered in English — and what the next voice will offer in whatever language is needed, in whatever place is most in need of it.

Each reader is somewhere on that map. Each reader is, at minimum, a possible listener. Whether one is also a possible speaker is a question the reflection cannot answer; it can only return.

A final word

These reflections began with a personal question and end with a question turned back on the reader. That is, in the writer's view, the proper shape of any wisdom inquiry: it begins inside one person's life and returns to inside every reader's life. It is not meant to settle anything; it is meant to clear a small space in which something old can be heard again.

The Gītā closes with Sañjaya, the narrator, saying: *wherever there is Kṛṣṇa, the Lord of yoga, and wherever there is Arjuna, the wielder of the bow, there will be prosperity, victory, well-being, and firm righteousness*. Read literally, this is a prophecy about the battlefield of Kurukṣetra. Read more carefully, it is a description of the structure of any human moment: *wherever consciousness and instrument come together — the inner Self and the willing hand — the upholding-truth is being upheld, regardless of what else is happening in the world*. This is, perhaps, the deepest hope the Gītā offers. The work of upholding the truth is never finished, and is never, in any single life or any single age, completed alone; but it is, also, never extinguished, as long as there remains one consciousness paired with one willing hand. That pairing has occurred in many languages, in many bodies, in many centuries. There is no reason to think it has stopped occurring now.

These reflections are offered in that hope. They will be misread. They will be ignored. They may, in some small place, by some particular reader, be heard. The writer does not know which, and is not, in the Gītā's own teaching, supposed to know. What the writer has done is done. What happens next belongs to the readers, and to whatever larger pattern these few words are a tiny part of.

karmaṇy evādhikāras te mā phaleṣu kadācana

"You have the right to the act. You do not have the right to its fruit."

iti śam — "thus, peace."

— the writer, with humility and gratitude.

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